- As for the evolution of the strategy and the higher direction of war during Operation Vijay, the MO operations' room was the hub of activities and we worked as a well-knit team. Lieutenant General N.C. Vij was the DGMO. Although we had the guidance and directions of the vice chief, the presence of the chief, General V.P. Malik, during the initial stage of this conflict would have made a difference. We made a number of presentations to the Cabinet Committee for Security (CCS), headed by Prime Minister A.B. Vajpayee, Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister L.K. Advani, Defence and External Affairs Minister Jaswant Singh, Finance Minister Yashwant Sinha, National Security Adviser Brajesh Mishra, the service chiefs, heads of IB and R&AW and the cabinet secretary, starting 18 May.

  At that time, based on the reports of the forward troops and formations as well as the IB and R&AW, our assessment of the intrusions was hazy. We accepted the analysis of HQ 15 Corps and Northern Command that the intruders were mujahideen who were being supported by the ISI and the Pakistan Army, and that they would be evicted in two or three weeks. Yet there was something that was not gelling. We had discussions in the MO directorate and started planning for various eventualities. Orders were given for certain forces to be sidestepped within the divisional sector, the corps zone and the command theatre and gathering of intelligence. Orders for relocation of some Army HQ reserves and other formations from the Eastern Command were also issued. The strategy that was emerging was to contain and limit the intrusions, punitive engagement with artillery, mortars, rockets and long-range direct firing weapons, isolation of the intruders, and their eviction in a systematic manner. In this period, certain hastily planned local actions taken at brigade and division levels met with failure and led to avoidable casualties. In the meanwhile, the Pakistani establishment continued to make ridiculous statements, such as the one by their foreign minister Sartaj Aziz, 'that the infiltrators could be fighters from Afghanistan who may have crossed the LoC in support of the local mujahideen forces, and that the LoC was vague and undefined.'[12]